

Primary Source Reading 1: Meno's List and the Bee

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Meno, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 3a: The Problem of Definition

Before you read: Meno, a confident young Thessalian who has studied with the Sophist Gorgias, opens the dialogue by asking Socrates whether virtue can be taught. Socrates says he cannot answer, because he does not even know what virtue is — and asks Meno to tell him. Meno's first answer looks like a perfectly reasonable list. Watch how Socrates uses a small, almost playful example — the bee — to show why a list is not what he asked for. The exchange ends with Meno, embarrassed and stuck, comparing Socrates to an electric fish.

What Is Virtue?

SOCRATES: How, if I know nothing at all of Meno, could I tell if he was fair, or the opposite of fair; rich and noble, or the reverse of rich and noble? Do you think that I could?

MENO: No, indeed. But are you in earnest, Socrates, in saying that you do not know what virtue is?

SOCRATES: Not only that, my dear boy, but you may say further that I have never known of any one else who did, in my judgment... By the gods, Meno, be generous, and tell me what you say that virtue is. (71a–d)

MENO: There will be no difficulty, Socrates, in answering your question. Let us take first the virtue of a man — he should know how to administer the state, and in the administration of it to benefit his friends and harm his enemies... A woman's virtue, if you wish to know about that, may also be easily described: her duty is to order her house, and keep what is indoors, and obey her husband. Every age, every condition of life, young or old, male or female, bond or free, has a different virtue: there are virtues numberless, and no lack of definitions of them. (71e–72a)

The Swarm of Bees

SOCRATES: How fortunate I am, Meno! When I ask you for one virtue, you present me with a swarm of them. Suppose that I carry on the figure of the swarm, and ask of you, What is the nature of the bee? and you answer that there are many kinds of bees, and I reply: But do bees differ as bees, because there are many and different kinds of them; or are they not rather to be distinguished by some other quality, as for example beauty, size, or shape? How would you answer me?

MENO: I should answer that bees do not differ from one another, as bees.

SOCRATES: And if I went on to say: That is what I desire to know, Meno; tell me what is the quality in which they do not differ, but are all alike — would you be able to answer?

MENO: I should.

SOCRATES: And so of the virtues, however many and different they may be, they have all a common nature which makes them virtues; and on this he who would answer the question, “What is virtue?” would do well to have his eye fixed. Do you understand?

MENO: I am beginning to understand; but I do not as yet take hold of the question as I could wish. (72a–d)

[Meno tries twice more. His second answer — virtue is the power of governing men — fails because it leaves out children and slaves, who have no one to govern but can still be virtuous or vicious. His third answer — virtue is the desire for beautiful things and the power to attain them — fails because everyone, virtuous or not, desires what they take to be good; the desire itself cannot be what distinguishes virtue. After this third failure, Meno turns the conversation on Socrates himself.]

The Torpedo Fish

MENO: O Socrates, I used to be told, before I knew you, that you were always doubting yourself and making others doubt; and now you are casting your spells over me, and I am simply getting bewitched and enchanted, and am at my wits' end. And if I may venture to make a jest upon you, you seem to me both in your appearance and in your power over others to be very like the flat torpedo fish, who torpifies those who come near him and touch him, as you have now torpified me, I think. For my soul and my tongue are really torpid, and I do not know how to answer you; and though I have been delivered of an infinite variety of speeches about virtue before now, and to many persons — and very good ones they were, as I thought — at this moment I cannot even say what virtue is.

SOCRATES: You are a rogue, Meno, and had all but caught me... As to my being a torpedo, if the torpedo is torpid as well as the cause of torpidity in others, then indeed I am a torpedo, but not otherwise; for I perplex others, not because I am clear, but because I am utterly perplexed myself. And now I know not what virtue is, and you seem to be in the same case, although you did once perhaps know before you touched me. However, I have no objection to join with you in the enquiry. (80a–d)

After you read: Notice what has actually happened here. Meno began the conversation certain that he could answer a simple question. Three attempts later, he cannot say what virtue is at all — and he is more troubled by this than by any insult Socrates could have offered him directly. As the next lesson will show, Socrates thinks this discomfort is not a defeat. It may be the first honest thing that has happened in the conversation.